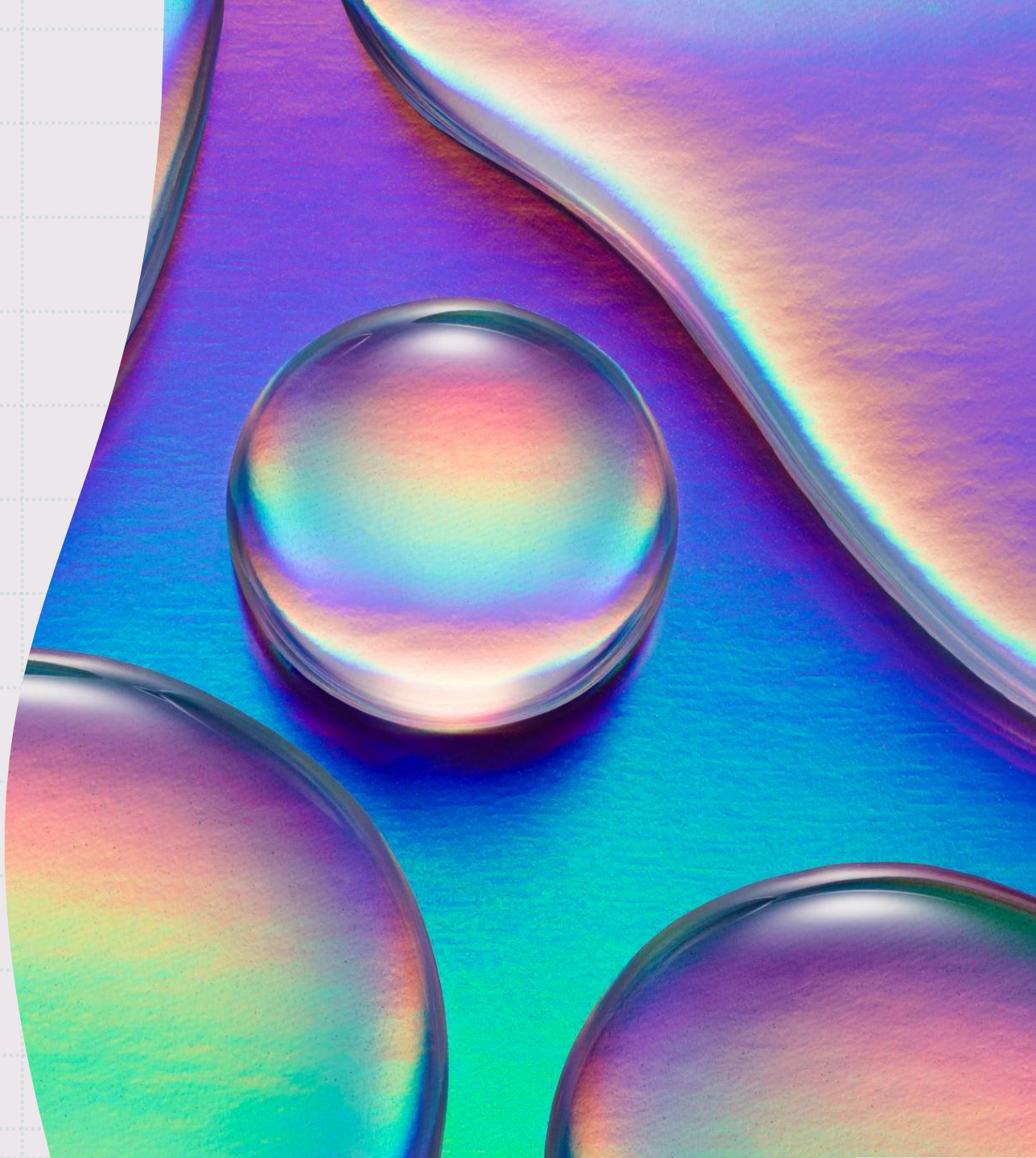
Holding the Intimacy Coaching Frame

The Coach/Client Relationship

Kai Cheng Thom, MSW, MSc Couple & Family Therapy, Certified Somatic Sex Educator



Learning Objectives

1

1. Be able to define and discuss intimacy and relationship coaching in personal and professional settings

2

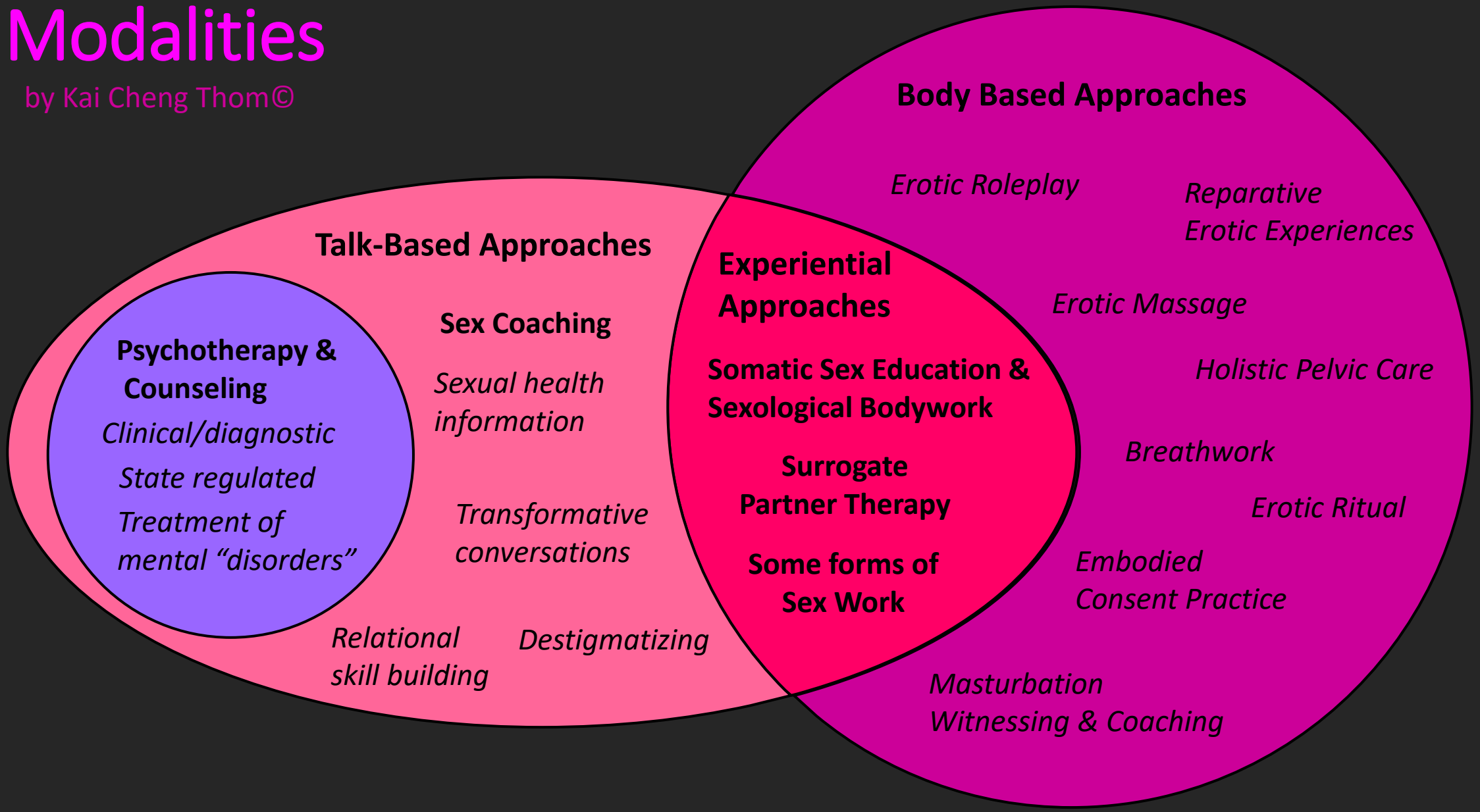
2. Identify the scope of practice of an intimacy and relationship coach, distinguishing it from sex therapy, psychotherapy, mental health practice, and other forms of healing and helping work

3

3. Understand important ethical issues in the sexuality field that are unique to working with intimacy and sexuality

Erotic Healing Modalities

by Kai Cheng Thom©



PLISSIT

PERMISSION

LIMITED **I**NFORMATION
SPECIFIC **S**UGGESTIONS

INTENSIVE **T**HERAPY



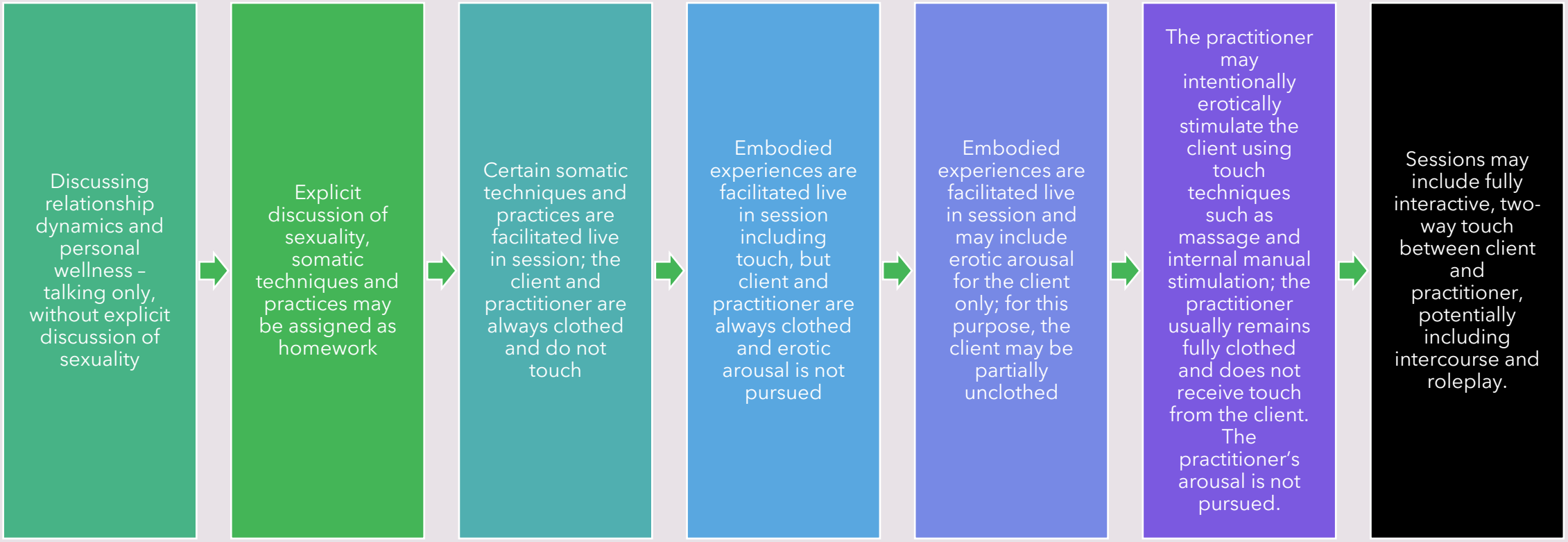
Intimacy Coaching & Scope of Practice

Intimacy coaching is an emergent field that covers many different professional mandates and scopes of practice

There are no universal standards defining or limiting the scope of practice of an intimacy coach, **however**, marriage/couples counseling or therapy, sex therapy, and other related professions may be regulated by medical and/or mental health licensing laws dependent on jurisdiction

The use of embodied erotic experiences, including guided visualization, movement, breathwork, masturbation coaching/witnessing, roleplay, and touch are often but not always considered core to the profession, yet are also heavily debated within therapeutic communities

Intimacy Coaching & The "Forbidden Zones"

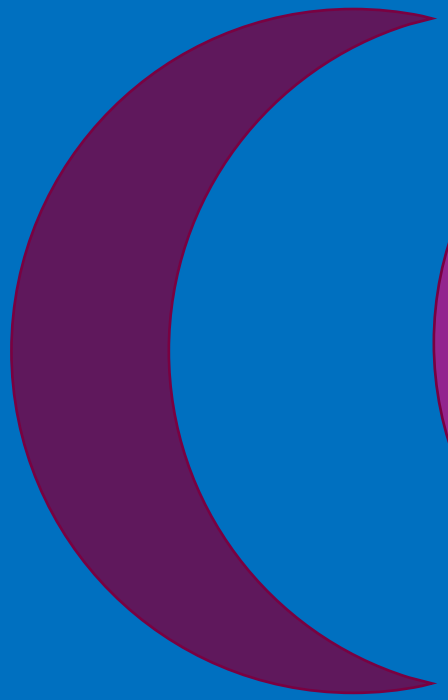


What is "forbidden" depends on legislation, professional and community standards, and embodied ethics

Spectrum of Consent

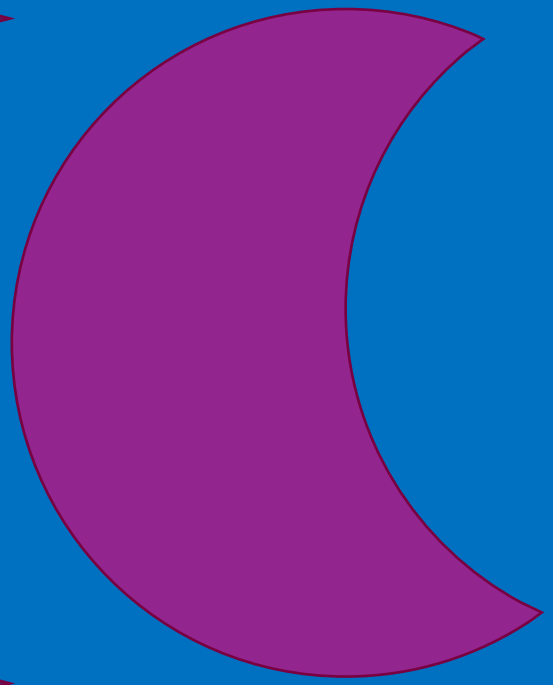
By Kai Cheng Thom, inspired by the work of Betty Martin

Enduring



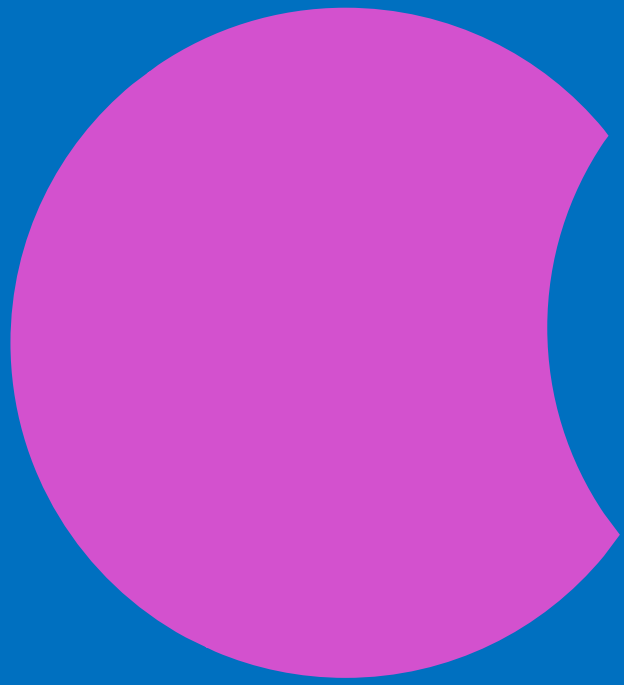
This is hurting me but I don't feel able to say no

Tolerating



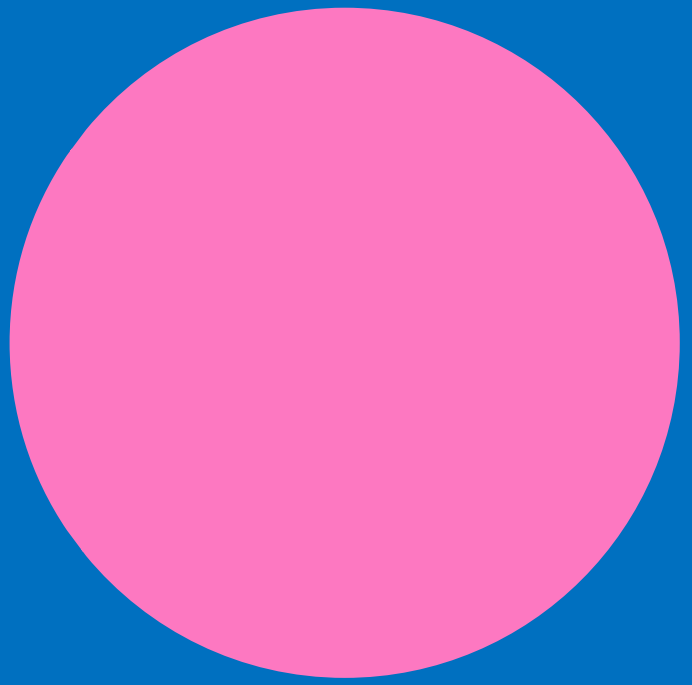
This is something I am putting up with

Willing



This is something I am "okay" or neutral about

Wanting



This makes me feel good

Key Scope of Practice Questions For Intimacy Coaches

What do I *want* to offer in my practice as an intimacy coach?

What am I *willing* to offer in my practice as an intimacy coach?

What am I *competent* to offer in my practice as an intimacy coach?

What are the resources, supports, and community of practice available to me when ethical dilemmas arise?

What are the resources, supports, and recourse options available to my clients when ethical dilemmas arise?

What laws and cultural norms must I consider as I build my practice?

What professional obligations, standards of practice, and ethical codes have I agreed to?

Embodied Intimacy Coaching & Sex Work

Most forms of embodied intimacy healing and sex therapy are derived from practices invented by sex workers, which in some cases were taken and taught by sexology/sex therapy researchers without credit

Historically, many intimacy healing professionals and sex therapists sought to distance themselves from sex workers in ways that were demeaning and degrading to sex workers

Not all embodied intimacy coaches are sex workers, but some sex workers may be intimacy coaches

Sex work is a highly stigmatized and complex industry that contains a vast range of individuals and experiences

It is an ethical imperative for coaches working in the field of intimacy and sexuality to educate ourselves on sex worker rights, and to develop the competency to discuss sex work and sex work clientship without stigma or prejudice

Recommended Reading:

- *Revolting Prostitutes* by Juno Mac and Molly Smith, https://www.versobooks.com/en-ca/products/548-revolting-prostitutes
- *Playing the Whore* by Melissa Gira Grant, https://www.versobooks.com/en-ca/products/2365-playing-the-whore

Sex Worker Wisdom

by Kai Cheng Thom©

Pleasure is worthy and worthwhile	Work should be pleasurable	Work should be well paid	Every body is capable of and deserving of pleasure	Purity & policing cannot destroy desire, only drive it underground
Violence is born not of pleasure, but of isolation	Pleasure is powerful	Pleasure transforms	Pleasure is possible	Pleasure heals

Essential Embodied Ethics for Intimacy Coaches

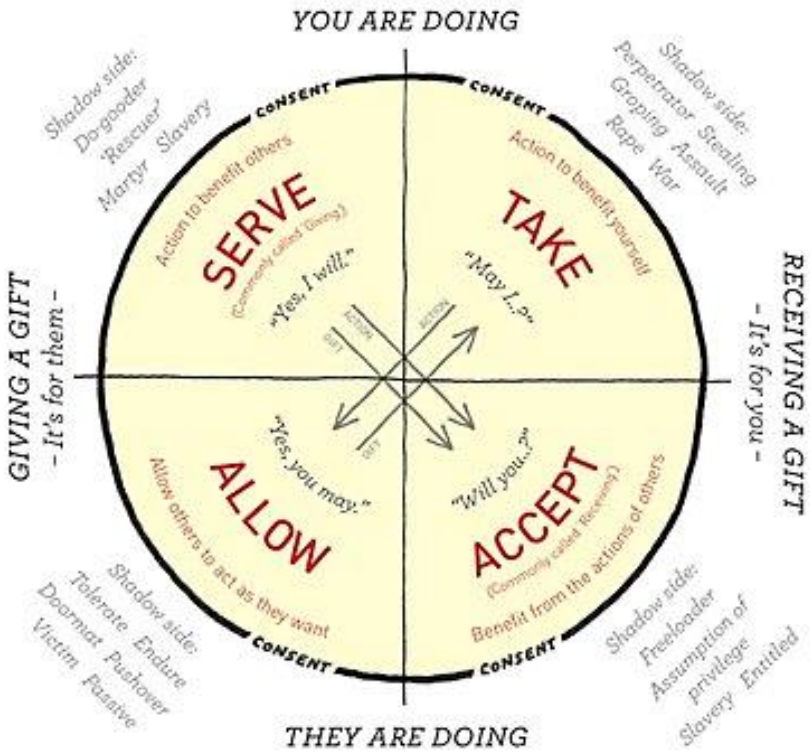
Intimacy and sexuality are taboo topics in the dominant culture; whatever your scope of practice as an intimacy coach, it is likely that your work will fall to some extent within the **counter-normative**

Intimacy coaching, sexuality coaching, neo-tantra, and related practice have powerful potential for individual and societal healing, but also enormous potential for harm to both client and practitioner. Remember: **Risk, harm, and abuse thrive in isolation.** Do not practice in isolation colleagues, mentors, supervision, and other forms of community of practice!

Above all, remember: What we are doing as intimacy coaches must always center and serve the needs of the client, and not our personal gratification. This should be a part of the consent to coaching process and regularly restated.

BETTY MARTIN'S WHEEL OF CONSENT

THE WHEEL OF CONSENT



In any instance of touch, there are two factors: who is doing and who it's for. Those two factors combine in four ways (quadrants). Each quadrant presents its own challenges, lessons and joys.

The circle represents consent (your agreement). Inside the circle there is a gift given and a gift received. Outside the circle (without consent) the same action becomes stealing, abusing, etc.

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Understanding Boundaries

by Kai Cheng Thom, adapted from the work of Betty Martin

